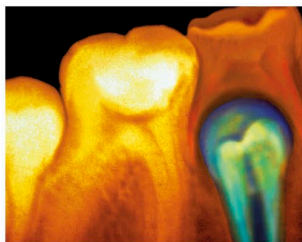


DENTAL DEVELOPMENT

The first set of teeth, known as the primary or deciduous dentition, erupts through the gums in a set order, from about six months into the third year. In general, apart from the canines, the teeth appear from the front to the back. However, the exact times and order vary between individuals, and occasionally a baby is born with one or more teeth. Primary teeth loosen and fall out as the adult, or permanent, dentition erupts through the gums. This usually starts at about six years of age. The set of 32 permanent teeth is complete once the third molars (known as wisdom teeth) appear in the late teens or early twenties. In some people, however, the third molars never make an appearance above the gum.



TOOTH ERUPTION

In this coloured X-ray, a permanent, or adult, tooth (green) is shown erupting under a child's milk, or deciduous, teeth.

STAGES OF DEVELOPMENT

Babies are born able to see, hear, and perform reflex actions, such as grasping, urination, and defecation. Gradually, the infant learns to bring these reflexes under conscious control. As the eyes develop the ability to focus clearly, the baby watches his or her hands, and learns how conscious movements formulated in the brain result in actual physical movement. During early childhood, these basic motor skills are refined further. The child also gains a range of social developmental skills, such as smiling, to elicit a response from those nearby. For most children, development takes place in a fairly

